23 THOUSAND Number of Indian seafarers affected by the war

$50 BILLION Annual remittances at stake

for that endeavour. Paramita Tripathi, the Indian ambassador to Kuwait, says that Indian workers are being assisted with transit visas to Saudi Arabia, from where they can fly home. A permit has been granted to Kuwait-based Jazeera Airways to operate flights to six Indian airports. Around 1,100 residents and the mortal remains of 17 have made that journey. Workers from Iraq have been asked to reach Riyadh, from where the Indian embassy takes over their travel.

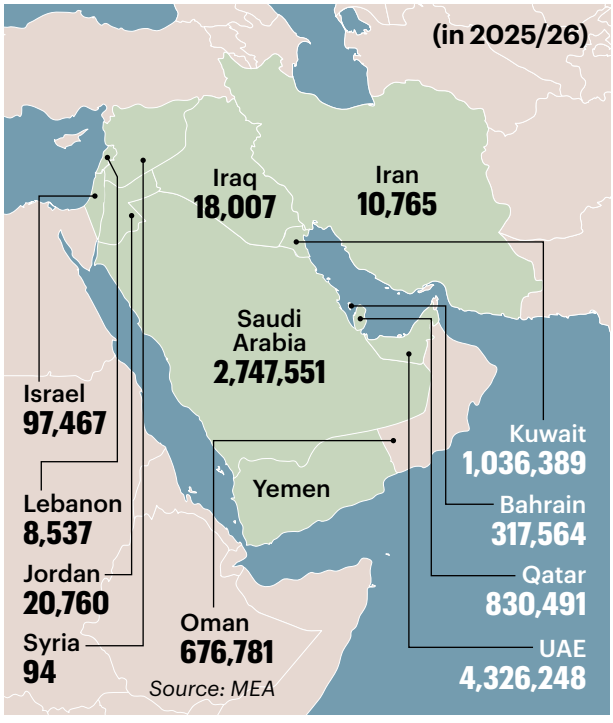
"EACH BLUE-COLLAR WORKER IN THE MIDDLE EAST EARNS AT LEAST THRICE AS MUCH AS HE WOULD EARN IN INDIA AND SUPPORTS A FAMILY OF FOUR BACK HOME. THEY ARE STAYING PUT FOR NOW"

— SHOBHANKITA REDDY
Research Analyst, Takshashila Institution



WHERE THEY ARE

Indian population by Middle East Country (in 2025/26)



Source: MEA

THE IMPACT

- Nine million Indians live in war-affected Middle East, two-thirds of whom work blue-collar jobs
- Around 23,000 Indian seafarers have been impacted so far
- $50 billion of annual remittances are in danger
- Staff sizes have shrunk, work hours have been reduced and shipments stalled
- CBSE-run exams of Class 10 and 12 students in Gulf countries stand cancelled

What more needs to be done

Job opportunities for the displaced will remain a concern as the war drags on, with $50 billion (Rs 4.66 lakh crore) worth of annual remittances from the Middle East at stake. Shobhankita Reddy, a research analyst at Takshashila Institution, says that while thousands of blue-collar workers have been sent on mandatory leave or are being called in for fewer hours, only a handful are returning to India. "Each blue-collar worker earns at least thrice as much as he would earn in India and supports a family back home. These are easily replaceable jobs, and the majority of them have chosen to stay put," she says.

Staffing at oil and LNG refineries in Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE will see a crunch due to the war wiping out facilities. Charith Konda, energy specialist (South Asia) at the Institute for Energy Economics and Financial Analysis, says, "Workforce composition will shift. Indians are employed across skill levels, but rebuilding will likely reduce high-value white-collar roles and increase blue-collar jobs."

Shiv Agarwal, of ABC Consultants, an executive search and talent advisory firm, believes it could safely be another six months before a large-scale reverse migration begins. "As of now, the returns are a trickle, but there is certainly a hiring freeze. Besides, talent is unwilling to accept positions in GCC [Gulf Cooperation Council] countries currently," he says. Lalu Samson, chairman of the Sharjah-based Indian Business and Professional Council, adds, "Tourism is indeed affected and staff has reduced shifts, but employers are keen to hold back trained workforce."

Perhaps the only demographic that might be a smidgen pleased by the ongoing crisis are the Class 10 and 12 students of GCC countries—220 schools run by the Central Board of Secondary Education have had their annual exams cancelled. ■